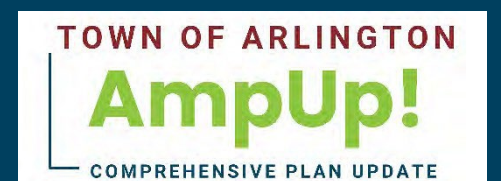
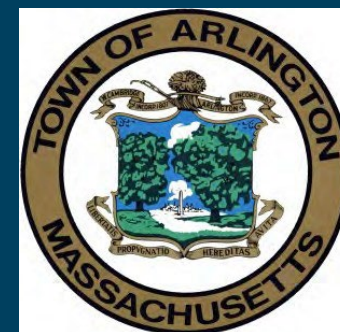




# COMPREHENSIVE PLAN TOWN OF ARLINGTON

Arlington Town Meeting May 2026

Claire Ricker, AICP – Director of Planning and Community Development



# What is a Comprehensive Plan?

- A **blueprint** to guide local government in achieving the community's vision.
- Provides a **basis for decision-** making about long-term physical development.



## ARLINGTON COMPREHENSIVE PLAN

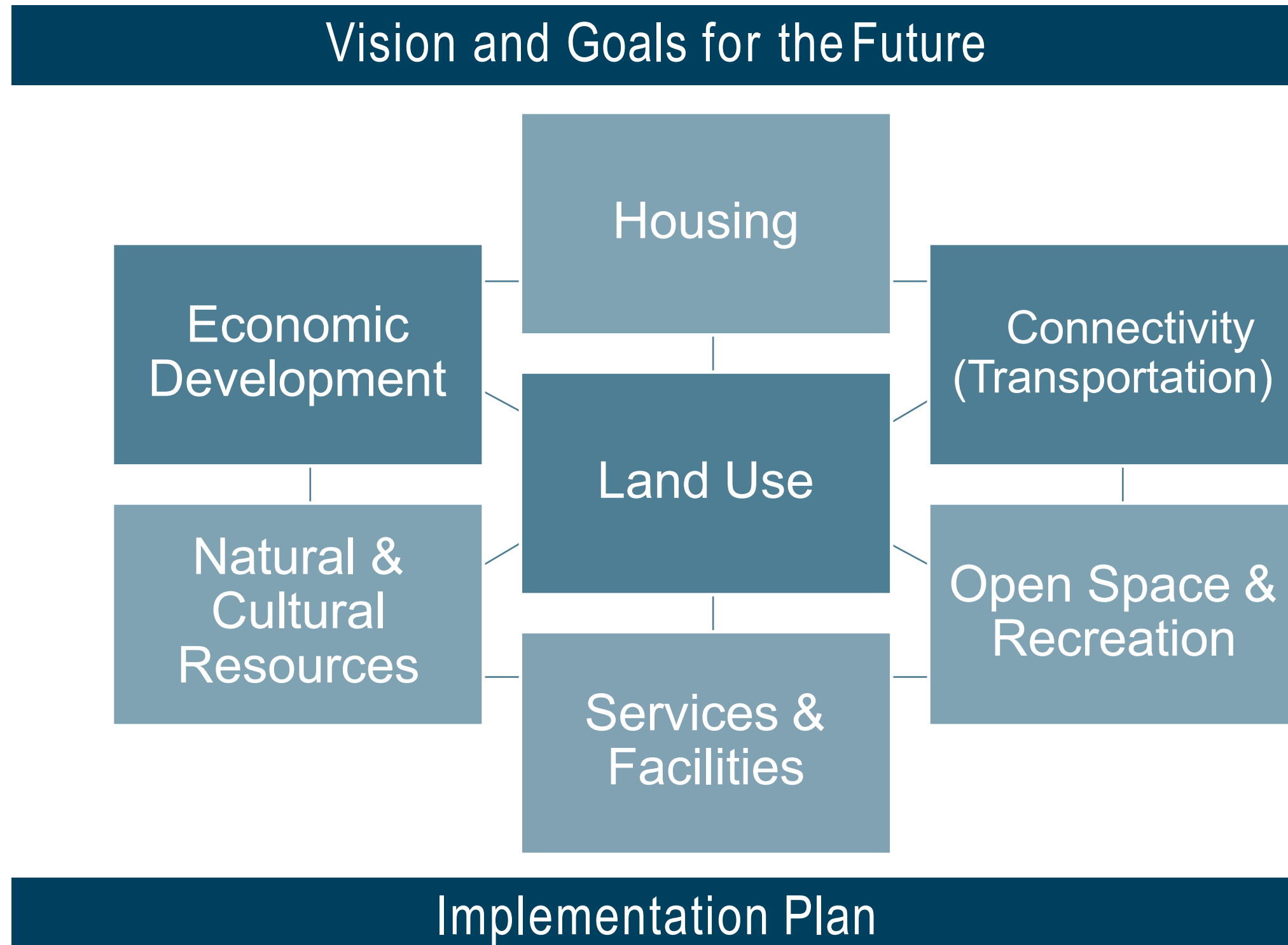
TOWN OF ARLINGTON

2026 Update



DRAFT FOR REVIEW MARCH 2026

# What's included in a Comprehensive Plan?



# 18-Month Planning Process

## Planning Process & Timeline





# // COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

# Engagement by the Numbers

200+

Attendees at  
in-person  
events

1,100

Contributors  
online

8

Interactive  
workshops & focus  
groups

3,435

Votes on  
**624** interactive  
map comments

100+

Surveys collected by  
AmpUp! members at  
20+ pop-up events

650+

Online survey  
responses

6,300+

Project  
website  
visitors

496

Responses to  
2 quick polls

# In-Person and Online Engagement Opportunities

- 3 interactive public workshops
- Extensive Committee member outreach at events like:
  - Farmers' Market
  - National Night Out
  - Summer concerts and beer gardens
  - Town Day 2025
- 5 focus group discussions
- Project website:
  - Surveys and quick polls
  - Interactive map
  - Meeting presentations and posters
  - Project documents



**TOWN OF ARLINGTON**  
**AmpUp!**  
COMPREHENSIVE PLAN UPDATE

English ▾

## AmpUp! Arlington's Comprehensive Plan

The Town of Arlington's comprehensive plan update will chart a course for the next ten years.

**The Town has launched a public planning process to update its future vision for planning and development in Arlington.**

The current plan was adopted in 2015 and much has changed since then. The comprehensive plan (formerly called the master plan) will serve as a guide for land use and development decisions and will include a ten-year implementation strategy to achieve that vision.

[Planning Process & Get Involved](#)

[Project Documents](#)

[Upcoming Events](#)

# Committee Outreach

- **20+** events attended by Committee members to promote process and hear from people
- **100+** paper surveys collected at events
- Focus group facilitation
- Engagement at public workshops and open houses



# AmpUp! Comprehensive Plan Update Advisory Committee

Eugene Benson

Angelique Bradford

Grant Cook

Rachel Dunham

David Fatula

Rebecca Gruber

Lillian Hartman

Ann LeRoyer

Cheryl Miller

Arthur Prokosch

Stephen Revilak

Tristan Roubenoff

Paul Selker

***Thank you!***



**TOWN OF ARLINGTON**  
**AmpUp!**  
COMPREHENSIVE PLAN UPDATE

# Draft Plan Comments

- Broad support for economic development, historic and cultural, connectivity, public facilities and services
- Diverse views on several land use and housing strategies, support for many others
- Comments discussed perceived tension between open space and development, and among recreation uses



| ces  |                                                         |            |      | TOWN OF ARLINGTON<br>AmpUp!<br>COMPREHENSIVE PLAN UPDATE                                                                                                                  |  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|------------|------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|
| D                                                                                       | PARTNER(S)*                                             | TIME-FRAME | TM** | COMMENTS                                                                                                                                                                  |  |
| C                                                                                       | DPCD                                                    | Mid        | N    | Create Develop + social media strategies to promote historic + cultural assets + attractions.                                                                             |  |
| ical<br>ession,<br>D                                                                    | Facilities, Town Manager                                | Ongoing    | N    |                                                                                                                                                                           |  |
| C                                                                                       | Historical Commission, Historic Districts Commission    | Short      | N    | Not all town history is relationship work! Spread the word! Find aerial navigation                                                                                        |  |
| ical<br>ession                                                                          | DPCD, ACAC                                              | Mid        | N    | Consider Historic Open Spaces for preservation                                                                                                                            |  |
| ical<br>ession                                                                          | Historic Districts Commission, DPCD                     | Ongoing    | N    | On HC-9, make attempts to involve young people in cultural events via outreach to AIS student body, and clubs (visual arts, music/poet, arts, etc.) and make telemonitory |  |
| ical<br>ession                                                                          | Historic Districts Commission, DPCD                     | Ongoing    | N    | Have more conversations with live music world and other businesses about ways we promote in living at Community                                                           |  |
| C                                                                                       | A-TED, Chamber of Commerce                              | Mid        | N    | On HC-13: Consider using blank party book at AIS to help find participants from your                                                                                      |  |
| C                                                                                       | Town Manager, DPCD                                      | ing        | N    | HC-5 Identify historic resources - input to GIS for mapping purposes                                                                                                      |  |
| C                                                                                       | DPCD, DEI                                               | ing        | N    |                                                                                                                                                                           |  |
| C                                                                                       | DPCD                                                    | ing        | N    |                                                                                                                                                                           |  |
| C                                                                                       | Recreation Department, DPW, Town Manager, Schools, DPCD | t          | N    |                                                                                                                                                                           |  |
| C                                                                                       | Town Manager, Facilities                                | Ongoing    | N    |                                                                                                                                                                           |  |
| D                                                                                       | Town Manager, Police, DPW                               | Mid        | N    |                                                                                                                                                                           |  |



PLAN DOCUMENT

# Comprehensive Plan Structure

Introduction

Community Engagement

Community Vision

Trends Influencing Arlington

Land Use

Economic Development

Housing

Connectivity

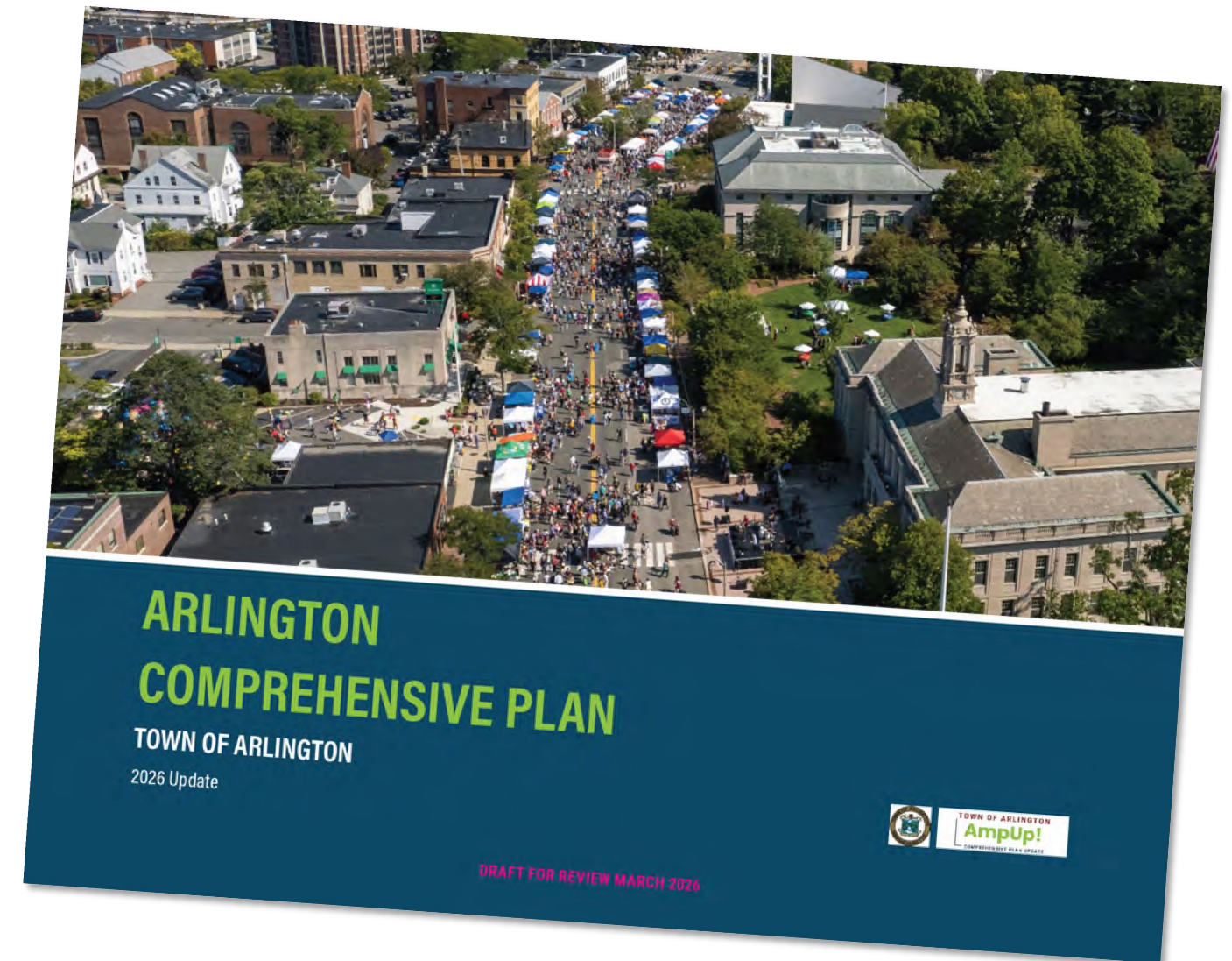
Historic & Cultural Resources

Natural Resources & Open Space

Public Facilities & Services

Implementation

- Goals & Strategies



# Topic Chapter Structure

## Overview

## Key Issues & Opportunities

## Relation to Other Plan Elements

## Strategy Summary

## Relation to Plan Themes

## Goals & Strategies

## Key Existing Conditions

Emphasizes interconnectedness – cannot consider one topic separate from others



# Two Plan Themes Addressed in Each Topic Chapter



## Supporting Equity and Diversity

- Welcoming community, quality of life
- Broad lens: physical accessibility, programmatic, language access, and more
- Access to resources and services, public spaces, community facilities



## Integrating Sustainability and Resilience

- Advancing toward the Town's net zero goal
- Sustainable building practices, green infrastructure, economic adaptability, social connections
- Proactive planning to better withstand and recover from future changes

# Vision Statement

**Arlington** strives to be a welcoming town that supports a diverse population in a variety of housing options, fosters thriving business districts and vibrant neighborhoods, protects the natural environment, and encourages a strong shared sense of community and civic involvement.

Key features will include:

- A variety of attainable housing options for all income levels and stages of life
- Thriving business districts with a range of job opportunities
- Inviting, safe streets for all users that link neighborhoods
- Healthy ecologies and resilient open spaces
- Stewardship and promotion of our historic heritage
- Cultural, arts, recreational, and educational resources that provide growth and shared experiences
- New development and redevelopment that enhances sustainability and resilience
- A shared interest in civic engagement and the Town's fiscal health

# Strategy Summary

## Land Use

- Strategic assessment of redevelopment opportunities to increase commercial and housing
- Bikeway as economic and housing amenity
- Role of Town-owned property to advance community goals
- Review zoning as implementation tool: project review timeline, uses, integrating local-serving businesses near neighborhoods

*Summary of recommendations — see plan document for full list of strategies*



# Strategy Summary

## Economic Development

- Develop a Strategic Economic Development Plan
- Streamline regulatory and permitting processes to support entrepreneurs and businesses
- Create a Placemaking Plan for business districts
- Improve Town's marketing and communications to attract/retain businesses

*Summary of recommendations — see plan document for full list of strategies*



# Strategy Summary

## Housing

- Amend zoning to allow greater range of housing types in more locations
- Identify recurring funding to support affordable housing development
- Align housing policy and net zero goals
- Increase development of ADUs

*Summary of recommendations — see plan document for full list of strategies*

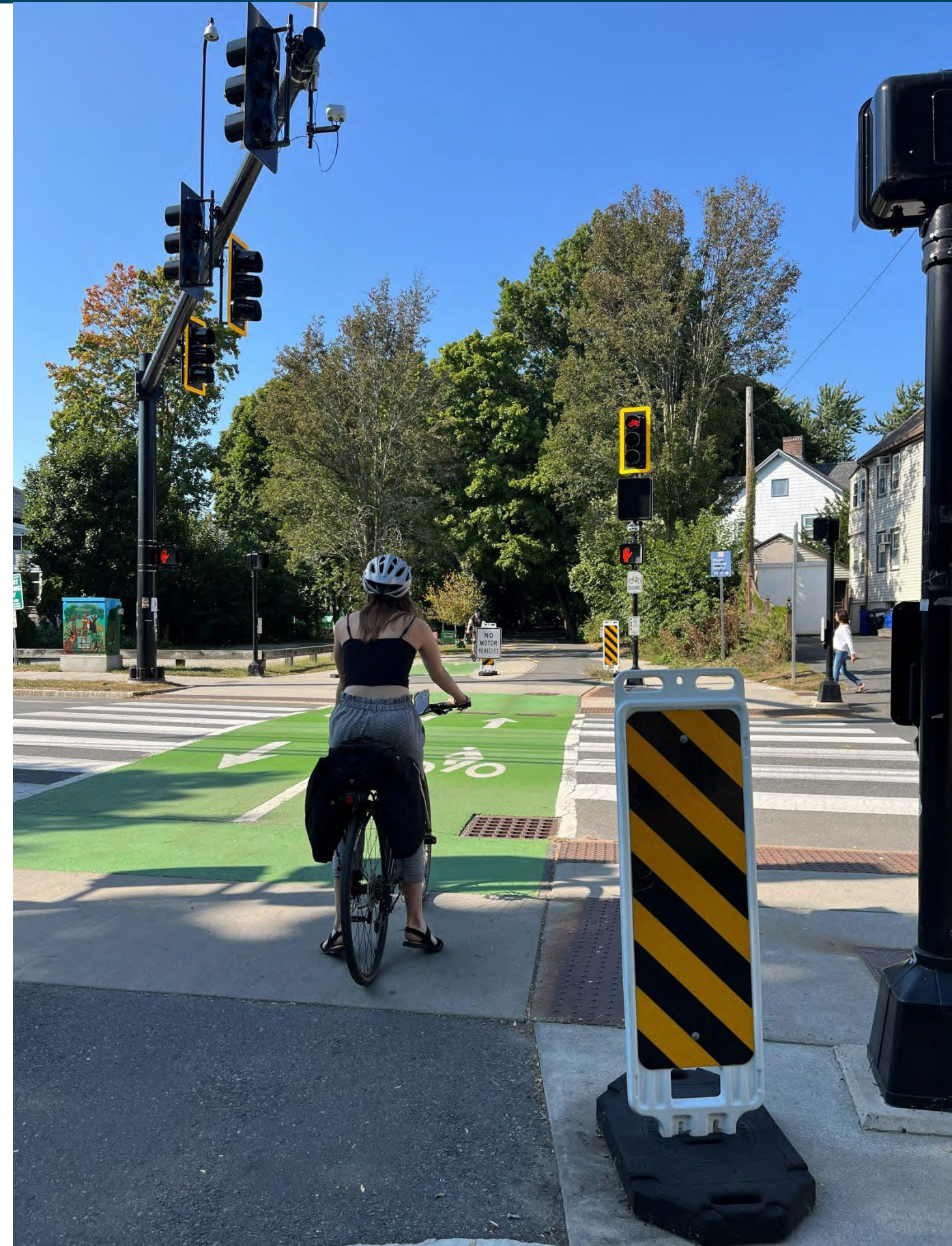


# Strategy Summary

## Connectivity

- Adopt Vision Zero policy to eliminate pedestrian and bicycle fatalities
- Review overnight parking in relation to housing and economic goals
- Study Mass Ave/Summer St connections for all users – existing and potential new
- Expand parking benefits districts to support streetscape improvements
- Advocate for transit improvements with MBTA

*Summary of recommendations – see plan document for full list of strategies*



# Strategy Summary

## Historic & Cultural Resources

- Update the Arts and Culture Plan
- Create a cohesive marketing and communications approach for local assets
- Preserve historic Town-owned buildings
- Identify public art opportunities in public and private spaces
- Address physical and programmatic barriers to historic and cultural resources

*Summary of recommendations — see plan document for full list of strategies*



# Strategy Summary

## Natural Resources & Open Space

- Continue to be a leader in sustainability and resiliency
- Mitigate urban heat island, localized flooding, and invasive species impacts
- Improve water quality in local water bodies
- Maintain and expand open spaces, tree canopy, and native plants

*Summary of recommendations – see plan document for full list of strategies*



# Strategy Summary

## Public Facilities & Services

- Continue progress toward eliminating building-related emissions to meet net zero goals
- Leverage technology for more efficient public services
- Address athletic field usage and maintenance
- Modernize Town-owned spaces and buildings for greater use
- Prepare plans for Town-owned facilities and for progressing toward zero waste

*Summary of recommendations — see plan document for full list of strategies*



# Implementation

## Roles

- Town departments
  - Town boards and committees
  - ARB, Select Board, and Town Manager
  - Town Meeting: zoning and budget-related especially
- 
- Near-term priorities – demonstrate progress in next couple years on key strategies
  - Zoning as one implementation tool – land use, housing, economic development especially
  - Acknowledges some strategies will require funding which should be considered relative to other needs





**THANK YOU!**

